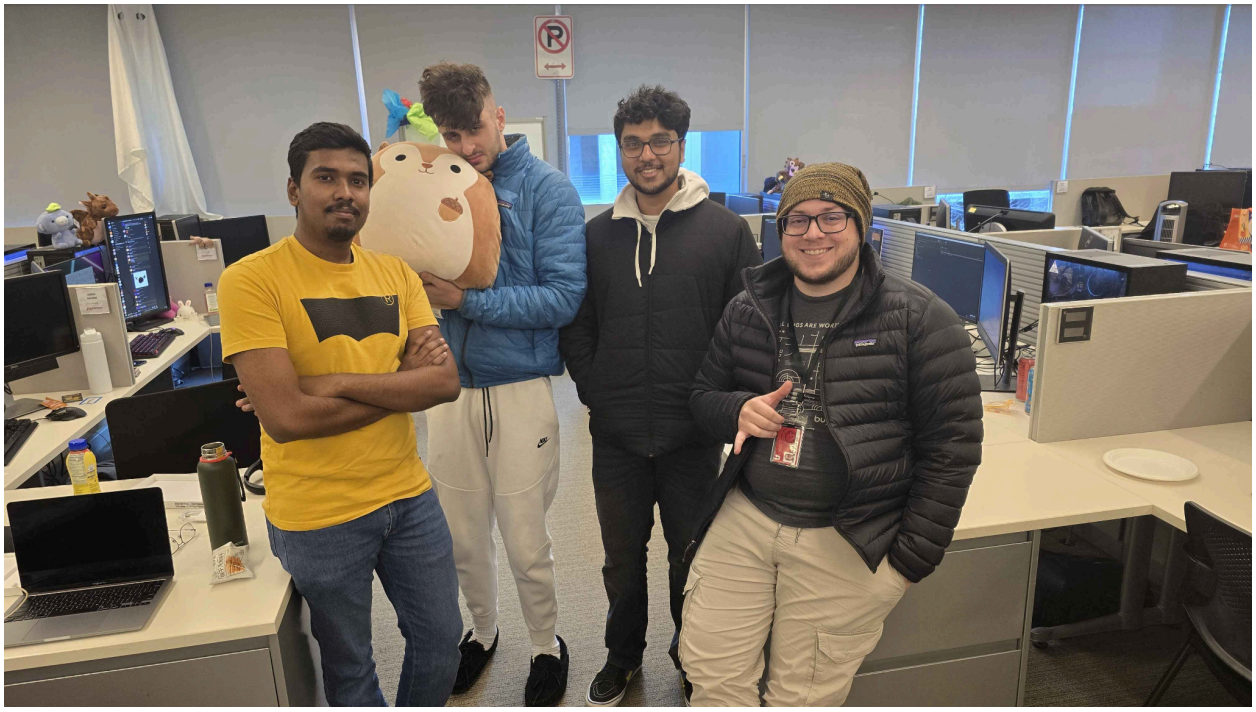
Castle of Cardboard Dev Diary

The Timeline for this project was rough for the Designers and Engineers. The first 2 weeks were spent on the general movement mechanics, interactable mechanics, and basic enemy functionality. After about week 3, we discovered enemy designs were not finalized or within scope. What did we do to accommodate this? That's right add more to the scope. Well… not entirely, but we didn't cut back as much as we should have; specifically, we removed the Slime enemy's ability to split when attacking it a certain way. Instead, we essentially retooled how AI worked, moving from behavior trees to states/events. This task wasn't done by an engineer, however, but instead by one of our designers who had extensive experience in Unreal Engine. While this did lead to a crunch and a non-engineer having to contribute more than they should have, this issue should have been dealt with by week 2, which is where the producers should have stepped in. As a team, we discussed all this in our post-mortem, in what I would consider a very successful way, not putting direct blame on anyone, but instead highlighting the issues and reflecting on how to go about them in future projects. The key takeaway from this experience is that scope and communication are some of the most critical components of working in larger teams, and it is ok to always ask questions to make sure there are no roadblocks.

Personally, I thought I contributed more than I was asked and was happy to do it. I view my time in this program as a way to grow both my programming skills and my professional collaboration skills. Although crunch isn't necessarily the way to go about it, I want to focus more of my time while enrolled on game development rather than outside distractions. Because of this approach, I was able to learn a lot more about Unreal Engine by exploring things from gameplay programming, sound effects, visual effects and implementation, anything UI, and just the most effective practices to save time. I want to specialize more in enemy AI, which was my primary focus; however, given time constraints, this task proved too big for just one engineer. Also, some miscommunication led to AI being reworked several times, taking away the already limited amount of time we had. There is still more work to be done, which we as a group are committed to doing, and getting it up on Itch and the Google Play Store. Now that

we have no set deadline, this gives me more time to experiment, research, and improve what we have in the game already.



The Crunch Crew

Reflecting on the overall group dynamic, it was rather difficult to interact with anyone outside of designers, producers, and engineers early on. As engineers, we didn't talk with the Artist due to how our row was laid out, but also because our task didn't overlap or rely on their work. That and anything we needed was passed through designers and producers first, so they were more or less our messengers. I think this approach is fine as the team is larger and it was more streamlined this way to avoid further miscommunications. After a mid-project meeting on the Thursday before Thanksgiving. We finally figured out our issues, which opened up the door for communication mainly between the tech artist and engineering, allowing us to collaborate more directly with them, but also because we needed to integrate their work within the main level. Although we got off to a slower start than we would like. I think the only issue was miscommunication, which more or less took a week away. In the final week, everything flowed smoothly, and the game went from panic mode to closer to what our final vision was. I think if we got that week back, we would have plenty more time to playtest and bug fix/polish.